Jimmy Lee 李兆康

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Fellow in Economics Sept 2024 – Aug 2026
Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

Visiting Scholar Jan 2025 – June 2026
Center for International Development, Harvard University

OTHER EMPLOYMENT

AI Trainer – Economics Expert (Flex time), SpaceXAI Apr 2026 – Present

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Program Evaluation and Scaling
Focus—Synergies between Agriculture, Rural Education, and Digital Technologies

Family Economics, Organizational Economics
Focus—Intergenerational Dynamics in Rural Household and Community Decision Making

Behavioral Economics with applications in program evaluation, agriculture, and education
Focus—Modeling how agents jointly choose how much weight to place on mental model(s) alternative to a default—possibly several at once—and how much effort to invest in acquiring information about a new situation, under neural capacity constraints

With implications for designing interventions that overcome preconceptions and stimulate curiosity, and for measuring beliefs under (possibly) multiple priors

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, Northwestern University 2024
M.Phil., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2017
B.SSc., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2015

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Miscategorization as an Information Friction: Activating School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia with Parental Engagement"
(Funded by AFD Fund for Innovation in Development, USAID-DIV, Wellspring Foundation, and FAO)

Schools in developing countries often have weak ties with parents. This paper studies whether development program success hinges on strengthening these ties. In a three-year Liberian experiment across 197 schools, I evaluate school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) against control, cross-randomizing parental engagement via promotional videos and field days. SBAE improves targeted outcomes only when paired with engagement: students' households adopt 26–53% more agricultural techniques, dropouts fall 4–5 percentage points per year, and absenteeism falls 28%. The program is more cost-effective than most extension programs in Africa and over twice as cost-effective as conditional cash transfers in raising attendance. Without it, SBAE's diffusion mechanisms via school demonstration farms, home projects, and intra-household communication stay muted—technology adoption effects vanish, absenteeism rises 31%, and parents reduce school visits below control. Parents' information avoidance, plus reversed effects under engagement, challenges standard Bayesian learning. I attribute these patterns to parents conflating SBAE with a discredited school-garden preconception.

OTHER PAPERS

"Communicating Parents' Beliefs to Students as a Pivotal Component of Parental Engagement: Evidence from School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia"
(Funded by NSF, Weiss Fund, Global Poverty Research Lab, and the Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)

When school programs require students to make changes on household farms, is informing parents about the program sufficient, or is further signaling their support to students needed? In a randomized evaluation of school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) across 197 Liberian schools, where students take school farm training into a home farming project, I design a nudge revealing to students their parents' optimism about their farm-management skills. Two years later, SBAE improves students' livelihoods and schooling only with it: income rises 63%, on-time school fee payment 43–47%, and cost-effectiveness for attendance doubles. Farm interactions unique to the targeted parent-student pair pinpoint the mechanism: even where engaged parents adopt promoted techniques, third-party communication is pivotal in shifting students away from subsistence farming.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Behavioral economic theory with applications in program evaluation, agriculture, and education

1. **"Default Mental Model, Alternative(s) Activation, and Information Acquisition under Neural Capacity Constraints: Theory and Belief Measurements"**

Policy paper with a model explaining SBAE's promise in an environment characterized by substantial heterogeneity in suitable agricultural technologies

2. **"Catalyzing Technology Diffusion in Africa through School-Based Agricultural Extension"** (joint with Chris Udry)

Scheduled RCTs on the scaling of SBAE in 2026-29

3. **"Learning to Learn: Synergizing Inquiry-based Science and Agricultural Transformation"** (joint with Vesall Nourani, Harvard GSE)
4. **"Parental Engagement in School-based Agricultural Extension: Testing Mechanisms at Scale"** (piloted interventions in 2025-26)

Long-run scaling of SBAE across Liberia, Côte d'Ivoire, and Kenya in 2026-35

5. **"Directed Technical Change under Customized Farming Advice: An Empirical Framework"** *(grant from Weiss Fund; piloted survey method; planning RCT)*
6. **"Parental Engagement and the Use of Unconditional Cash Transfers"**

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

During postdoctoral studies:

National Chung Cheng University; NYU Africa House–Center for Technology, Economics, and Development (CTED); Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P); Tel Aviv University; Oklahoma State University; Harvard Graduate School of Education; Harvard Center for International Development; Africa Food Systems Forum 2024

During PhD:

Meeting of the Society of Economics of the Household (SEHO); J-PAL—Middle East and North Africa (MENA); CGIAR—Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA); International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI); University of Glasgow; National Graduate Institute for Policy Studies (GRIPS, Tokyo); Development Day 2023

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Total program evaluation and academic research grants secured for SBAE in Liberia: **$4.2 million**

Program Evaluation Grants

AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI)	2025
J-PAL Learning for All Initiative: Scaling Award ($222K; co-PI)	2024
USAID Development Innovation Ventures ($395K; co-PI)	2022
Wellspring Foundation ($192K; co-PI)	2022
AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI)	2021
Food and Agriculture Organization ($68K; co-PI)	2021

Academic Research Awards

J-PAL Learning for All Initiative ($400K; co-PI)	2025

Weiss Fund ($5K; Lead PI) 2022
National Science Foundation ($451K; co-PI) 2020
Weiss Fund ($29K; Lead PI) 2020
Global Poverty Research Lab ($19K; Lead PI) 2019
Buffett Institute for Global Affairs ($5K; Lead PI) 2019

TEACHING

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University

Introduction to Microeconomics, Introduction to Macroeconomics, Intermediate Microeconomics II, Intermediate Macroeconomics, International Trade, Economics of Nonprofit Organizations

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Citizenship: Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, China
Languages: English (fluent), French (intermediate), Mandarin (fluent), Cantonese (native)
Programming: Stata, R, Matlab, Python, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

REFERENCES

Professor Christopher Udry (Chair)
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